BROADWAY MARKET INTELLIGENCE

Revenue & Demand Analysis (1995–2020)

145 Productions | 47,500+ Weekly Records | 25 Years

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Project Summary

This project analyzes 25 years of Broadway performance data (145 productions, 47,500+ weekly records) to identify the financial and operational drivers of commercial success in live entertainment.

Using PostgreSQL, I designed a normalized relational database and developed advanced SQL queries leveraging CTEs, window functions, and multi-table joins to evaluate award impact, production type risk-return profiles, launch timing effects, and capacity utilization as a predictor of sustainability.

+38%

Avg weekly gross increase
in 26-week post-award window

~2x

Revenue for fall launches
vs. spring openings

82%+

Capacity threshold predicting
10+ year viability

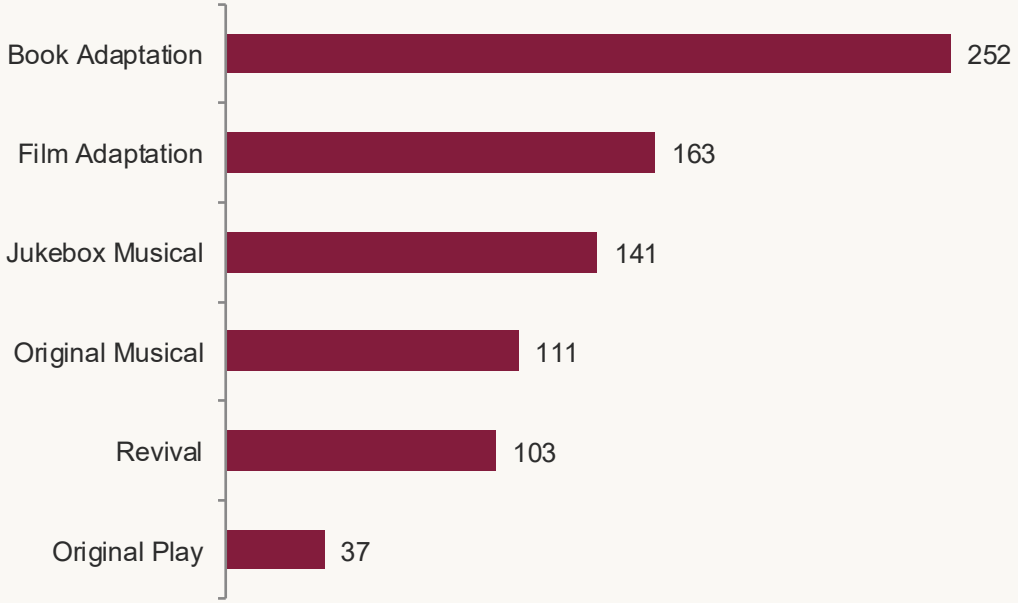
Skills: PostgreSQL, relational database design, advanced SQL (CTEs, window functions), event impact analysis, KPI development, multi-metric performance modeling

Business Questions

Evaluate drivers of revenue growth, retention, and long-term commercial success across 25 years of Broadway market data.

1. Does award recognition materially impact revenue?
2. What predicts long-term run sustainability?
3. Does pricing suppress demand?
4. How should producers allocate risk between originals and adaptations?
5. Does launch timing affect commercial outcomes?

01 Industry Overview: Performance by Category



Key Insight

Revivals and Film Adaptations make up 53% of all productions — the industry leans heavily on proven IP.

Every show in the top 15 by gross is a musical.

Musicals: $152M avg
Plays: $37M avg

Book Adaptations lead at $275M avg, driven by Wicked ($1.36B), Phantom ($1.03B) and Hamilton ($645M).

Film Adaptations are second at $162M avg, driven by The Lion King ($1.68B) and Aladdin ($459M).

Story point: A risk-averse industry relying on proven IP — but original works offer the highest upside.

02 Market Health: A 25-Year Growth Story

4x

Revenue Growth
$445M → $1.82B

3x

Ticket Price Growth
$42 → $125

21/25

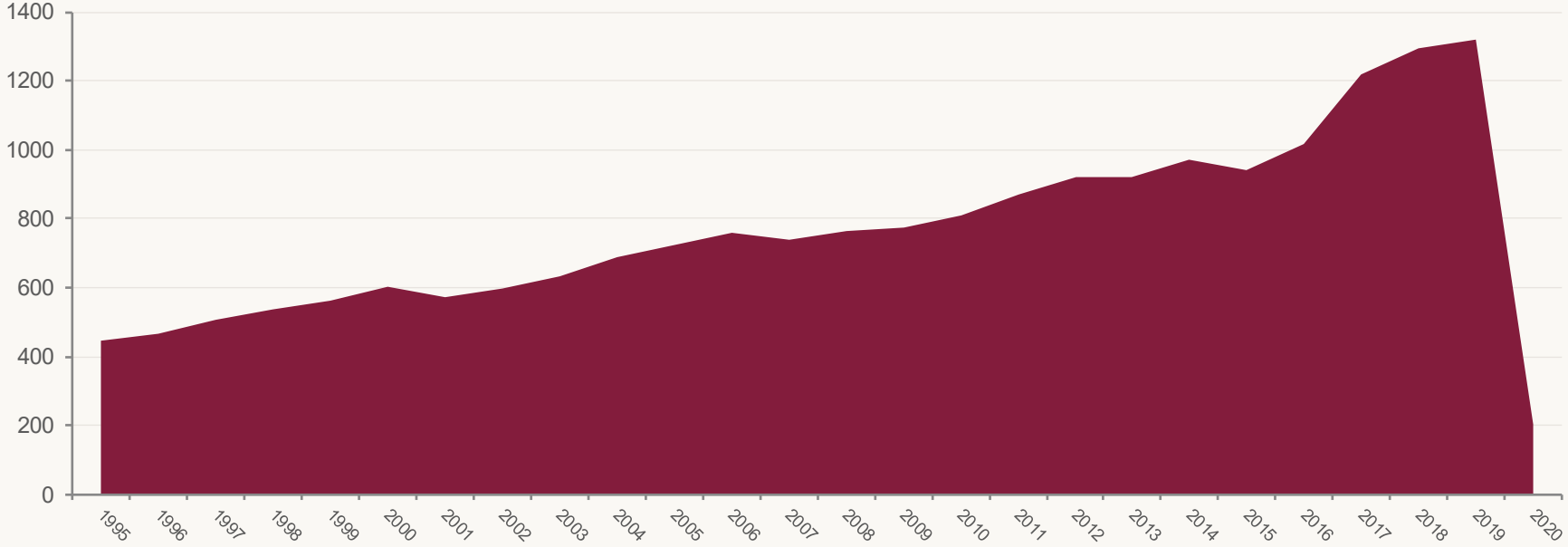
Growth Years
Remarkable resilience

Critical Finding: Pricing Power

Ticket prices tripled without suppressing demand. Capacity actually increased from 81.7% to 90.2%, demonstrating the market was historically underpriced. The 2017 season saw +19.8% growth, the largest single-year jump, driven by the Hamilton phenomenon.

Story point: Rising prices strengthened - not weakened - demand. The market supports premium pricing.

02 Total Industry Revenue (1995–2020)



Only 4 down years in 25. Broadway grew in 21 of 25 years. 2020 COVID shutdown collapsed revenue -84.5%. Further analysis needed on how industry rebound post COVID.

03 Tony Awards: Winners vs. Non-Winners

WINNER	$200M Avg Total Gross	NON-WINNER $114M	+75%
WINNER	217 wks Avg Run Length	NON-WINNER 158 wks	+37%
WINNER	85.7% Avg Capacity	NON-WINNER 80.9%	+5 pts

Story point: Tony winners outperform across every major metric. Recognition and revenue are strongly linked.

03 Post-Award Revenue Lift: Before vs. After

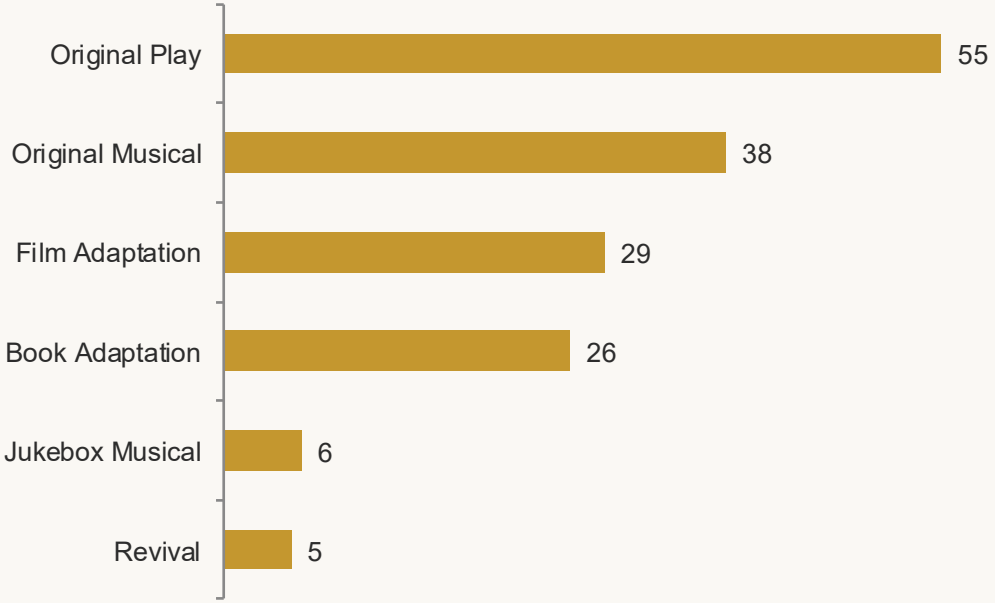
Avg weekly gross: 26 weeks pre-ceremony vs. 26 weeks post-ceremony (Best Musical winners)

Show	Year	Before (Weekly)	After (Weekly)	% Change
Titanic	1997	$350,874	$687,223	**+95.9%**
A Gentleman's Guide	2014	$500,577	$882,002	**+76.2%**
In the Heights	2008	$521,065	$863,807	**+65.8%**
Kinky Boots	2013	$997,034	$1,625,491	**+63.0%**
Hamilton	2016	$1,660,132	$2,206,230	**+32.9%**
The Band's Visit	2018	$862,504	$860,066	**–0.3%**

Average across 22 Best Musical winners: **+38% increase in weekly gross** (26-week post-award period)

Caveat: Post-award window coincides with summer tourism season. Correlation does not establish causation: the award may reflect underlying quality and demand momentum.

04 Production Strategy: Award Recognition by Type



Strategic Tension

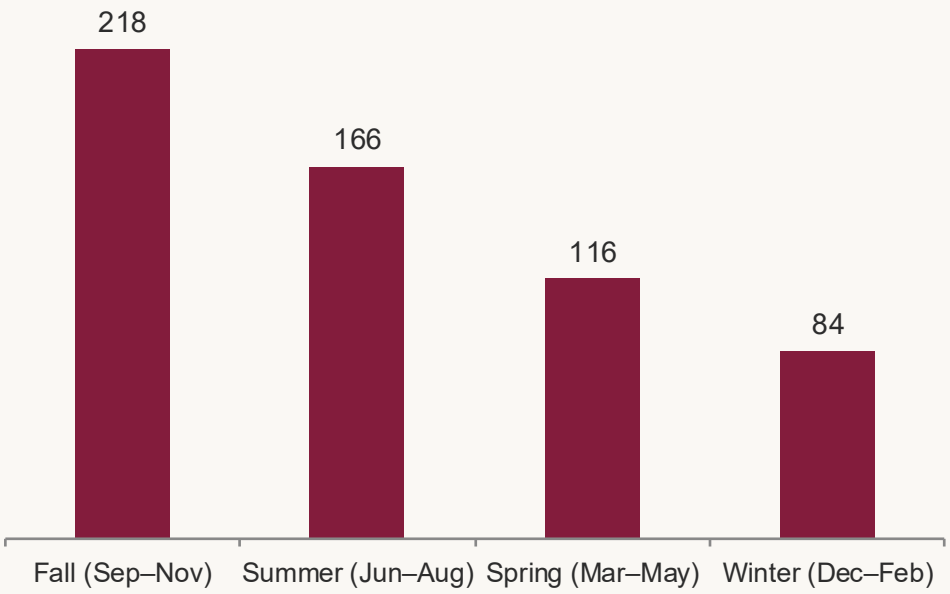
Original works win Tonys at 3–10x the rate of Jukebox Musicals and Revivals.

But adaptations and revivals make up 53% of all productions, indicating lower risk with built-in audience awareness.

Originals = higher risk, higher award upside

Story point: Originals win awards; adaptations fill seats. A balanced portfolio hedges risk while pursuing upside.

05 Launch Timing Strategy



Autumn Advantage

Autumn launches earn nearly 2x spring revenue ($218M vs. $116M) despite spring being the most popular window (74 shows).

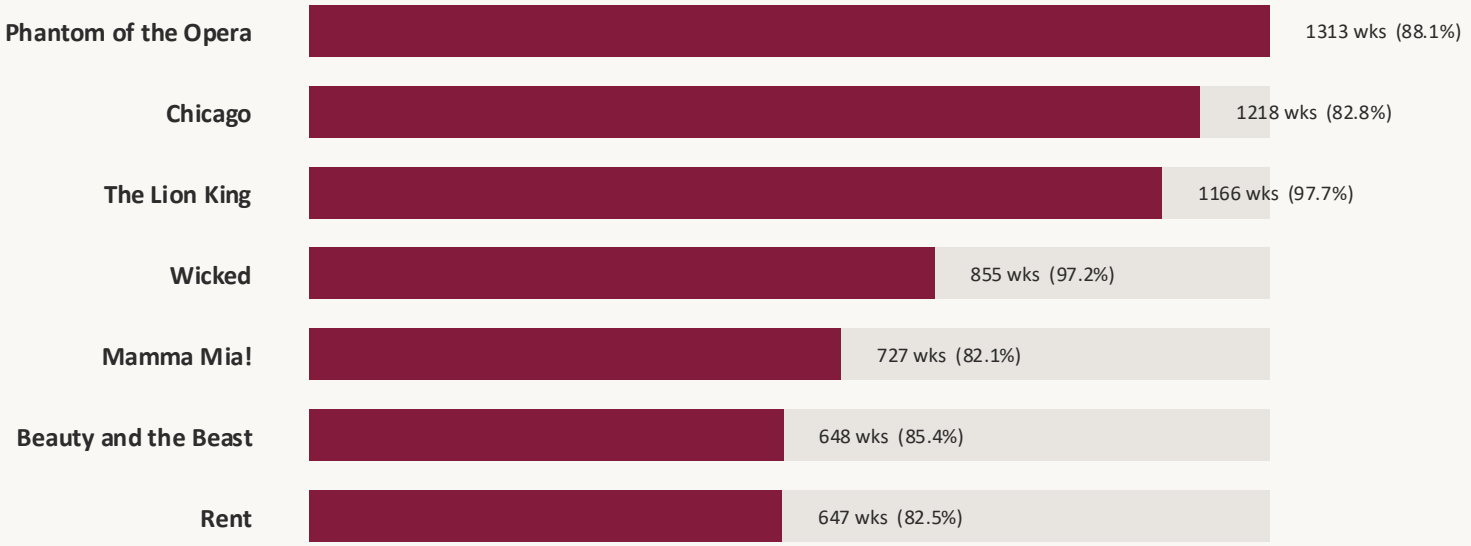
Why autumn works:

1. Build momentum through holiday season
2. Full season before June Tony eligibility
3. Less crowded competitive window

Story point: Producers should prioritize fall openings, especially for Tony-eligible productions.

06 Longevity: What Predicts 10+ Year Runs?

Only 9 shows ran 10+ years — all musicals, all sustained 82%+ capacity



Story point: Sustained capacity above 82% , not peak revenue , is the strongest predictor of longevity.
**Dataset ends March 2020. Shows like Hamilton (opened 2015) have since surpassed 10 years but are reflected here with only their pre-2020 data.*

07 Multi-Factor Success Framework

Composite score combining 4 dimensions to evaluate productions holistically

Tony Recognition	Audience Demand	Longevity	Revenue
25 pts win + 2/nom	5–20 pts (capacity)	10–30 pts (run length)	Tiebreaker metric

#	Show	Category	Score	Gross ($M)	Capacity
1	The Lion King	Film Adaptation	**97**	$1,677.80	97.7%
2	Book of Mormon	Original Musical	**93**	$656.78	102.3%
3	Hamilton	Book Adaptation	**87**	$645.34	101.7%
4	Hairspray	Film Adaptation	**81**	$252.18	89.1%
5	The Producers	Film Adaptation	**80**	$288.36	84.9%

Story point: The most successful shows excel across all dimensions rather than dominating in just one.

08 Business Impact Summary

Finding	Metric	Strategic Implication
Post-Award Revenue Lift	**+38% avg weekly gross (26-week window)**	Award campaign investment has measurable upside
Fall Launch Advantage	**~2x revenue vs. spring openings**	Prioritize fall launches for Tony-eligible shows
Capacity Sustainability	**82%+ predicts 10+ year runs**	Monitor as leading indicator for extension decisions
Original vs. Adaptation	**3–10x higher award win rate**	Balance portfolio with higher-risk originals
Pricing Power	**Prices 3x, demand held**	Market supports premium pricing strategy

09 Limitations & Future Work

Limitations

- Post-award analysis does not control for summer tourism seasonality
- No control group of nominees who did not win
- Correlation ≠ causation: awards may reflect underlying quality
- Category classification involved judgment calls for edge cases
- Broadway-only gross; excludes touring, international, licensing

Future Enhancements

- Add control group of Tony nominees who didn't win
- Apply statistical significance testing (t-test)
- Incorporate audience demographic data
- Add social media and digital marketing metrics (2010+)
- Expand scope to include touring and international revenue
- Extend analysis post-2020 to evaluate industry recovery from COVID shutdown

Data & Methodology: Primary dataset: Alex Cookson / TidyTuesday Broadway Weekly Grosses (47,524 records, 1985–2020). AI tools were used to assist with structuring the Excel workbook and matching show names from the original dataset. Show metadata (type, category, dates) was manually researched and classified using IBDB.com and Wikipedia. Tony Awards data was manually collected and verified from tonyawards.com. AI tools (Claude) were used to assist with presentation structure and formatting. All analysis, data collection, and findings are original work.

Thank You

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